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Small Struggles: Essays

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The Back Seat

Junior high to grade 10, about 2022–2024, Semarang

The first time, the rider told me not to bother with a helmet. “Ga ush gaush pake kan cuman deket deket doang.” No need, it’s just nearby. He wasn’t wearing one either. It was night, at the end of grade 8, and he was a younger kid from my school. I got on the back.

Nearby turned out to be four or five kilometres from my house, on back roads. He took them at seventy, eighty kilometres an hour. He laughed at first. He was trying to scare me, and he knew it was working.

I didn’t scream. I complained. Out loud, properly, until he dropped to fifty or sixty. When I got home my hands were cold. In one version of this memory they weren’t shaking. In another, they shook a little. I’ve told it both ways, and I can’t tell you which one is right. What I’m sure of is my heart going *deg deg an*, pounding, during the fast part.

I rode with him exactly once. In grade 9, I said no.

That should be the end of the story. It isn’t, because the back seat kept finding me.

There was a classmate in junior high who gave me a lift for group work. Neither of us had a helmet. He only went about sixty, but he weaved. For a long time I remembered him slipping past trucks with almost no gap, again and again. Later I started to doubt that. When I really go back, the only thing I can find is the feeling of holding the grip behind me. Not comfortable. Not scared. Alert. The trucks may be something my brain added afterwards to make the feeling make sense.

There was a close friend in junior high who took me to school for about a month. Seventy to ninety, tailgating trucks. Once an *angkot*, a minibus, started to cut across in front of us, and its side mirror went past at head height. “Lewat di kepala.” Right past my head.

And in grade 10 there was my deskmate, on a CBR 150. A hundred on the big road. Once a hundred and twenty, downhill. Three or four round trips of ten kilometres in my first semester. I told him. He stayed *ngeyel*, stubborn, about it. Eventually he stopped wanting to give me rides, and I’d already signalled that I didn’t fit his style. Nobody said anything dramatic. It just stopped.

Here’s the part that still feels unreal. All four of the people who gave me those rides crashed later.

The younger kid crashed riding home from school, no helmet. Lumps on his head, his face bleeding, bandages everywhere. My close friend tore his leg open from the upper thigh to the buttock. The other two had lighter crashes. I wasn't on the back for any of them.

I don't really believe in signs. But when I lined the four of them up, it felt like they were telling me something. Do what they don't do.

So I don't. I'm the only boy in my class who has never ridden a motorbike without a licence, a SIM. Part of that is timing: COVID hit in grades 5 and 6, right when other kids were learning. Part of it is that as a small child I fell off my bike a lot. These days I rarely ride with friends at all. Only when something actually matters.

The strange thing about fear is how badly it records. My hands went cold on those rides. That was real. But it faded almost immediately. What I remember far more clearly is a moment with no danger in it at all. My father, in traffic, with a BRT bus behind us. He just calmly eased our motorbike out of its way. No speeding. No drama. I can still see it.

I think the speeding rides were noise and my father was a signal. One showed me what people do when they want to feel something. The other showed me what an adult does when someone is sitting behind him.

I didn't need a crash of my own to work out which one I wanted to be. I did need four crashes, all of them other people's, to stop telling myself I was being overcautious.

Saying no in grade 9 cost me almost nothing. I lost a ride. That was the whole bill. I think about that when I'm tempted to go along with something because refusing feels awkward. Awkward is cheap. The back seat isn't.

Five Days

Grade 10, 2025, Ungaran

A geography teacher walked into my class in the middle of grade 10 and offered places in the school's selection for the Earth Science olympiad, OSN Kebumian. My deskmate and I wanted it, for no particular reason. It was *iseng*, a whim. Earth science wasn't even my field. If anything it should have been economics.

The school gave us about five months to prepare alongside normal schoolwork, plus five days of formal training it paid for. I didn't really use the five months. I used the five days. I went all in on those, and it was enough.

I placed third in the district round for Kabupaten Semarang. I was one of four students from Smada, my school, SMA N 2 Ungaran, to go through to the provincial round, and the youngest of the four. The only one from my year. An older student had once told me that five *months* wasn't enough to prepare for the district round. I'd done it on five days. I'm not saying that to brag. I'm saying it because it set me up for what came next.

The provincial round came with a dispensation: about a month and a week fully out of class. As I wrote later, we were "left largely to our own devices." There was a five-day provincial training, offline, at a training institution whose CEO was involved. One of my good friends there was an older student from my school, an Informatics silver medallist, who was mentoring at the same place.

The teaching in that training wasn't good. And I wasn't fully in it. I kept asking myself whether learning earth science had good enough leverage, before I'd even learned much of it. I told myself I'd use the time around the olympiad to learn crypto and AI and apply to YC. Afterwards I kept making excuses about school leaving me no time.

I didn't make nationals.

Months later I explained it in one sentence: "itu agak nampar gua di OSNP dimana gw kurang belajar banget, Dan pelatihan 5 hari OSNP itu kurang bagus pengajarnya, jadi gw ga Lolos osn nasional karena ngandelin raw talent." It slapped me a bit at the provincial round. I studied far too little, the teaching in the five-day training wasn't good, so I didn't make nationals because I relied on raw talent.

Nampar. To slap. That's the right word. It wasn't a punch. Nobody gets hurt by a provincial olympiad. But it stung in a specific place: the place where I'd been quietly proud that five days was enough.

The big hit landed in early September. Then smaller versions kept landing, in the small competitions after that, in October and November. Same lesson, lower volume.

There was a cost I didn't count at the time. That dispensation, plus another for an APBN competition (a quiz on the state budget) that I also didn't win, meant I was out of class for almost two months in one semester. My grades felt it. That became its own story.

There was a cost inside my head too. After failing nationals I became *pasrah*, resigned, and started to "follow the wave." I drifted away from olympiads toward research and startups. Some of that was a real change of direction. Some of it, I suspect, was walking away from a place where I'd been embarrassed.

When I tried to write about it for a university application, I kept getting stuck. My research was my own choice. The olympiad wasn't. A teacher picked me, and it wasn't my field. It's hard to tell a good story about something you never fully chose.

What I eventually wrote was this: after the olympiad window closed I felt a strange mix of relief and regret. Relief that I'd learned fast. Regret that I hadn't turned that learning into a clearer contribution.

Both are still true. People at school still call me *anak OSN*, the OSN kid. I'm still the only one from my year who went. I'm also the one who found out where raw talent runs out. It runs out somewhere between the district and the province, right about where five days stops being a flex and becomes an excuse.

Fast learning gets you into the room. It doesn't tell you what to do once you're in there. I knew how to sprint. Nobody had made me practise the part after the sprint, and I hadn't made myself.

Unwritten Rules

2025, Ungaran

The DM was polite, specific, and completely wrong.

"Gua punya ide bisnis kecil yang butuh sedikit approve dari lu Tim." I have a small business idea that needs a bit of your approval, Tim. I'd watched almost every video by Timothy Ronald, the finance YouTuber. I'd built a ChatGPT character that copied his sarcastic style, maybe 20 to 30 percent of how he talks and thinks, and I wanted to sell it as an AI product. I even had a name: Ronald 1,0V.

He didn't reply. Of course he didn't. I couldn't even set up an API yet. I thought about tagging him in an Instagram story and decided against it. "Nanti dianggap ngemis." I'd look like I was begging. The experiment cost me something else, too. The imitation got so exact that I left my main ChatGPT account, and lost the old chats about my plans and my schoolwork with it.

That was the loud rule: big people don't owe you an answer. The quiet rules were closer to home.

Early in grade 11, a group of older students known as *agak nakal*, a bit naughty, kept calling my name. I turned, and they went silent. Another one called. Someone asked whether that was even my name. I felt awkward, so I just turned and said "hai." They all laughed.

My friends took it badly. To them it was mockery, being looked down on. I wasn't so sure. I think it was just a different way of talking. Those two worlds can't be mixed carelessly, but it isn't impossible. Later, a lot of the boys who used to hiss-call me started asking my name politely, or kept quiet around me in case I got offended like before.

Then my olympiad teammates taught me about *Mas* and *Mbak*, the Javanese words for older brother and older sister that you're supposed to use for seniors.

I messaged an older boy: "Mas, besok tuh ada blabla gak?" Mas, is there such-and-such tomorrow? He replied normally. The next day he told me in person that messages to seniors should open with a greeting, *kayak ngomong ke guru*, like talking to a teacher. I thought that was really weird. I'd used "Mas." I also noticed that he'd felt friendless at his own provincial round, because he was so stiff about politeness.

The second time, I mentioned an older girl to a teacher by her bare name, without "Mbak." She felt offended. To her face I always say Mbak, the same way I address my own older sister. It hadn't occurred to me that the rule still applied when she wasn't in the room.

The irony: the seniors everyone calls naughty are the ones who call me "Mas."

I still don't care much about age gaps between students. It's a few years. But I've stopped assuming a rule is stupid just because nobody wrote it down. These rules are a map of what people need in order to feel respected. The idol needed distance. The naughty boys needed me not to flinch. The polite senior needed a greeting.

None of it was in any rulebook. All of it was the test.

Twelve of Thirty-Six

December 2025, Ungaran

When report cards came out at the end of the first semester of grade 11, my number was 12. Out of 36.

People were confused. I understood why. The provincial olympiad had put me on the school's Instagram. In my class, a science class I call the *kelas kompetitif*, the competitive class, filled with former top students, I'd become the smart one. Then the rank came out, and the smart one was in the middle.

I wrote about it a few days later. "Gw merasa sedikit ternodai karena panggung Lolos ke OSNP." I feel a little tainted by the stage of making provincials.

Tainted is a strange word for an achievement. But that's how it felt. The olympiad didn't change my grades. It changed what people expected my grades to say. My marks had always been ordinary. In grade 10 I ranked third, then fourth. In primary school I never ranked at all. The odd thing is that my grades kept going up the whole time. From third to fourth, they rose. From fourth to twelfth, they rose a little again. The rank fell because the room changed. The competitive class was filtered, mostly students who'd ranked near the top of their grade-10 classes. In any other science class, I'd clearly have been top ten. I knew that. It's just very hard to explain a denominator to people who only see the numerator. The validation kept coming anyway, and it weighed on me. Not because I mind expectations. Because it wasn't the real me.

A teacher said in class that some people are good at economics and some are good at history. Nobody was named. I knew it was about me.

At home it landed differently. At rank 12 of 36 in a competitive class, I was seen as having failed. As someone who couldn't get into a top state university through SNBP, the admission route that uses report-card grades. Later a teacher told me SNBP was still possible, but with no guarantee of Undip.

The part that hurt wasn't the judgment. It was recognising it. I'd carried a feeling of not being enough for a long time. Now it seemed to have been planted in my parents too. It was as if I wasn't allowed to be an ordinary person, even though in primary school I'd never been anything else.

So I did what I always do. I built a defence.

I had remedial tests in only three or four of fourteen subjects. Half my class had remedials. The top three had about two each. By that measure I should have been top five to seven. My average was around 88 out of 100. The top student in the year had 92. That put me in roughly the top fifteen percent of the school.

There was a reason, too. That semester I'd been out of class for almost two months on dispensation, for the provincial olympiad and for an APBN competition I didn't win. Both were backed by official school letters. You can't miss two months of lessons and expect your grades to stay where they were.

All of it was true. None of it changed the number.

What I eventually admitted was simpler. "Permainan gw aja gak cocok sama Dunia akademik nasional." My game doesn't even fit the national academic world. I'd been playing for olympiads, research and applications abroad, not for the report card. I can't then be upset when the report card doesn't reward a game I wasn't playing.

I also admitted something less comfortable. I'm maybe not confident about top-20 colleges. The defence I'd built was partly for my parents and partly for me.

Rank 12 isn't a failure. I can show that with numbers. It just wasn't the story people had written for me after the Instagram post. The gap between the post and the paper was mine to carry, and I didn't enjoy carrying it.

Here's where I've landed. Being seen as smart is a loan. People lend you their expectations, and you pay interest whether you asked for the loan or not. The only way out is to stop arguing about the interest rate and decide what you're actually building. For me that meant research and building things. The report card could stay ordinary. I'd stop pretending it wasn't.

Forty

December 2025 – February 2026, Ungaran

The rotation-geometry exam gave us an hour and thirty minutes. I finished in fifteen. I wasn't fast. I was scribbling.

Everyone assumed I'd scored 100. That's what happens when people call you "AI" and "prof" and treat you as the olympiad successor. Of the twenty-odd students from my year in the competitive class, I was the only one who'd made it through an olympiad selection. I could talk about topology and manifolds, the Millennium Prize problems, Perelman's papers on arXiv.

I scored 40.

When friends asked, I had an answer ready. "Gw lagi test baseline kemampuan matematika tanpa dikasih Tau rumus apa apa." I was testing my baseline math ability without being told any formulas. Just basic concepts, one minute per question by the wall clock. "So I am basically stupid untuk bisa construct mathematical model di otak gw." So basically I'm too stupid to build the mathematical model in my head.

It sounded like a scientist talking. It was half true. I really had stopped following math lessons after the first week, and spent the next two months thinking about my own projects. I really did want to see what I could do in a real exam with no grade to chase.

But a few weeks later, when I told the whole thing to ChatGPT, I told it as a story about someone else. An interesting classmate. The quiet grinder I sit behind. Strange results, uneven effort, nobody in his class able to guess whether his grades would be good or bad. I described him for a long time.

Then I wrote: "Orang itu sebenarnya gw sih." That person is actually me.

I'm not fully sure why I did it that way. Partly I wanted an outside opinion, and I don't have friends who are AI or software engineers to ask. Partly, I think, it was easier to look at the 40 from one seat back.

Looked at directly, it wasn't a clean experiment. I felt guilty for using a semester exam just to test my baseline. A friend could tell during the exam that I wasn't really trying, and I felt something was wrong there. I felt girls stopped coming up to me. Nobody praised me any more. That semester I ranked 12 of 36.

And when friends asked what I was really doing, I didn't tell them. "Ah enggak, gw fokus akademik sekarang." Nah, I'm focused on academics now, doing research with the science-club adviser, better to lock in a top university first. That January I'd actually missed school three times, and on those days I was messaging people abroad about an AI-adoption project.

There's an older habit under all this. Since grade 10 I'd had what I call leaks. School is a scam. The education system doesn't work. I had a stock line for classmates who worried about tests: "Lucu, ulangan aku mah nol juga gpp, gak peduli… Lucu ulangan aja takut." Funny. Me, I'd be fine with a zero, I don't care. Funny how you're scared of a mere test.

On the day I'm thinking of, I kept it to myself. But I'd said versions of it plenty of times before. And I'll be honest about where it came from. Not understanding. I'd realised a little, and I couldn't hold it in.

A 40 is a bad look for someone who says tests don't matter. It means either you're right and you didn't care, or you did care and lost. I'm still not sure which it was. A few weeks later my heart was pounding before a physics test, as if I cared about grades. I noticed that.

The honest version is this. On the outside I'd become a slightly unstable schoolkid. Not ready for research, and scared of it. Not ready for a startup, and not brave enough to build an MVP. "Gw seakan pindah medan doang tanpa improvement besar." It was like I'd just moved to a different battlefield without getting much better.

So in the second semester of grade 11 I shut my mouth. I stopped mouthing off with my hangout friends about why school doesn't matter, and chose to quietly work on something instead. I'd still rather spend a semester on university applications than on test revision. That was my decision, and I'll own it. But I'll own it without the speech.

The 40 didn't teach me much geometry. It taught me something about stories. If I have to tell one in the third person before I can look at it, it's about me, and I already know what's wrong with it.

Second Place

January – March 2026, Ungaran

The night before the English quiz bowl, I spent the last few hours drilling general-knowledge questions. Three of us were representing the school. We came second. I carried most of our team's score. I'll say that plainly, because it was the only part of this story I was sure about at the time.

A girl on the team took the team photo on her own phone. That's rare. Usually someone uses yours. I forgot about it and walked off while she was looking through the pictures. She caught up with me to get my number. Back at school I sent a thanks. She said you're welcome. I followed her private Instagram. She accepted immediately and followed back.

That was it. That was the whole event. And it wrecked my nights.

Normally at night I do what I call quiet grinding, the work I do alone on my own projects. Instead I was going through her Instagram. "Gw jarang banget suka/crush cewe," I wrote. I very rarely have a crush. I didn't know what to do with the feeling except be annoyed at how distracting it was.

Then a teacher needed a photo of us for the school's Instagram. I went to get her. Her classroom had no teacher in it and was completely silent. I walked straight in and called out her name, a little loudly. I told her we needed a photo. I didn't hesitate, didn't grin, didn't back out. I've described it as being in a trance. She was a little surprised and a little pleased, though probably half of that was the photo.

After that I couldn't get over her.

We talked about books once. She likes art and novels. She asked what I'd read in the library. I told her that a book by a former president had brought a few tears to my eyes. It was SBY's *Pasti Bisa*, because of the 2004 Aceh tsunami. I can't bear to look at it. Then I worried I'd overshared.

There was a gap, and I could see it. She was preparing for the national university entrance exam and dreamed of ITB. She'd posted a photo in an ITB jacket borrowed at a campus expo. I was preparing for an application abroad and doing research. We were thinking in different horizons. I took three days off my own work because thinking about her made me lazy. In early February I wrote: "lol, now I realize how a bit freaky I am."

By March it had gone strange. Nothing direct. Liked posts. Instagram notes. Codes. She posted a story: "bro literally read an actual book instead of consuming YT short and Tiktok." I replied and asked if it was about me, and said I doomscroll sometimes too. About a minute of nothing. Then, in capitals: "BUKANNN SERIUS BUKAN." No, seriously not. It was a dig at a friend of hers from Bogor. "For funsies only."

In person she avoided me. Ducked her head, looked away. She greeted me once, when she couldn't get out of it. When I suggested studying together in the library, or entering a competition as a team, it never happened.

It took me a month and a few days to see the pattern. “Gw harusnya udh dari dulu tarik diri.” I should have pulled back long ago.

So I did. Nothing dramatic. I just stopped reaching.

What I wrote then still sounds right. “Kek mending ngomong langsung daripada code code pake liked post.” Better to just say things directly than send codes through liked posts. I’m not good at codes. I don’t think I want to get good at them.

And this: “Gw suka kok sama dia, tapi… gak akan jadi siapa siapa di hidup gw.” I do like her. But she won’t be anyone in my life.

That isn’t bitterness. It’s the size of the thing, measured honestly. A first real crush on a teammate after a quiz bowl, a few lost nights, one walk into a silent classroom. It felt enormous. It was small. Both are true.

The trance in that classroom was real, though. I’d never walked into a room like that before, not caring what anyone thought. I’d like to find that state again for things that are mine. A person isn’t a project, and you can’t grind your way into someone’s attention. Pulling back wasn’t losing. It was giving my nights back to the work that had been waiting for me the whole time.

Not Aimed at Any Competition

2025 – July 2026, Ungaran

The message to my teacher took a long time to write. The answer took about a sentence.

“Saya akhir ini kan lagi suka baca baca journal bu…” Ma’am, I’ve been reading journals lately, and I’d like to do independent research. Not for a peer-reviewed journal, just a working paper on SSRN or arXiv, with the school’s name on it. Could I get one or two days a week of dispensation for about a month?

I had reasons. I lead the school’s science club, KIR. My class is *ribut banget*, really noisy, and at exam time everyone is like *cacing kepanasan*, worms on hot ground. I wanted to research decentralization in Proof-of-Stake blockchains. The club’s adviser, a chemistry teacher, didn’t get blockchain. Stumbled over a white paper, called it a scam, stayed doubtful, I think mostly because it was unfamiliar. The papers were in English, too.

The answer was no. “Gw gak dapet dispensasi karena emang gak diarahin ke lomba apa apa.” I didn’t get the dispensation because it wasn’t aimed at any competition.

My first reaction was petty, and I’ll keep it in. Weird, I thought. The school would still get its name on the paper. Fine. If that’s how it is, I won’t bother putting the school’s name on it. I’ll just write “independent researcher.”

My second reaction took longer. If research with no competition attached got turned down, even politely, then asking for time off to build a business would get me seen as an anomaly, an opportunist, or a daydreamer. I didn’t tell my family about any of it. I knew what I’d hear: “mending realistis aja.” Better be realistic.

I tried going around the school. I wanted to do the research with a lecturer at Undip, the university near my house. I reached out. It didn’t work.

This wasn’t the first proposal of mine to go nowhere. In 2025, for OPSI, the national high-school research competition, I’d written a proposal on the barriers to implementing OSS-RBA, Indonesia’s online risk-based business licensing system, at the provincial licensing office. The proposal passed. And then I didn’t do the research. I told myself it wasn’t challenging enough and I’d picked the wrong institution. Later I admitted the real reason: it didn’t suit a high-schooler. Too broad. Too technical.

So I had a pattern. A proposal passes and I drop it. A proposal I care about gets refused.

In March I pivoted to something with a competition attached, because that’s what the system rewards. A new OPSI project: a micro-learning system to introduce cloud accounting to micro food businesses in Banyumanik, with a pre-test and a post-test on at least ten vendors. It was a better question. I liked it.

Then came the partner problem. By May I could put in four or five hours in a day and have the structure and content of chapters one to three. My partner, who was only editing, took a week to revise. Honestly, OPSI itself mattered less to me than the fieldwork: going out and helping real business owners with financial literacy. That was the part I wanted.

By July my partner had stopped answering. I let it go. The next day I sat through a competition meeting and got scolded by a teacher for not continuing OPSI. That teacher, the head of OPSI at school, was hard on anyone who wasn't producing, partly because they didn't know what was going on inside my team. My own supervisor was fairly understanding. That helped a little.

Through all of this, I kept starting new research ideas. That's the honest part. By July I was working on a self-directed paper about AI-washing on the Indonesian stock exchange, aimed at *Finance Research Letters*. I had an AI help draft a research protocol, and I kept one line it wrote: "Idea-switching under setback is a known personal failure mode of the author; this document exists partly to make the pre-committed path harder to abandon than to follow."

I didn't write that sentence. I didn't delete it either, because it's right.

The refusals weren't the real struggle. Schools support what they can count, and a working paper on SSRN doesn't count for much on a trophy shelf. I can be annoyed by that and still understand it.

The real struggle was what I did after each no. I switched. Every refusal felt like permission to start over somewhere more interesting. Starting over feels like progress until you count how many chapter ones you've written.

A no from a school tells me something about the school. What I do with the no tells me something about me.

The Report

June – July 2026, Semarang

The first thing I checked was whether I was being cringe.

"Tapi ini beneran tindakan yang benar kan?... Jadi harusnya ini gak cringe kan?" This really is the right thing to do, right? So it's not cringe, right?

I'd come across a video on X. I'm not going to describe it. What matters is that it showed a high-school girl in Jakarta who had not agreed to be filmed, that her face was clear, that her school's logo was visible, and that it was being reposted.

I'd seen things like it before. A lot of them, honestly, for a long time. Every time I felt the same thing: helpless in the eyes of Indonesian law. Most victims have no real power except going viral, and going viral just spreads the thing further. So I'd always scrolled past.

This time was different because someone could actually be reached. There was a face and a school. Someone with real authority could act.

It was harder than it should have been.

The police cyber-patrol website wouldn't load for me. The school had five campuses, and I didn't know which one she went to. Their concern form assumed the person reporting was a student who knew the victim. I used Google Lens and traced the video to five reposting accounts. The oldest post was from 30 May, more than eight days earlier. It had already spread, and the posts were busy. I wondered whether reporting was even worth it any more.

I decided it was. I wrote that this was the first time I was actually following up on one of these.

The school listed WhatsApp contacts by campus, with no central number, and business hours on weekdays until 3:30 p.m. I picked one campus, not all five. I didn't want fragmented coordination. Let one office know, and let them coordinate from there.

They replied and asked me to fill in their child-safety form. I answered what I knew and put "N/S" for what I didn't. I gave links to all five posts. Strangely, they didn't ask for the video itself.

That morning I'd also tried the police Super App, at 7 a.m. Its online reporting was down. By eight or nine it was working. By then I'd decided I didn't have enough information to file a police report myself. The school was the right door.

Then something I'm not proud of. I caught myself curious. I wanted to know who she was. I wanted to tell her I was the one who reported it. I wrote that down too, because I'd rather be honest about it. In the same breath I wrote that we were too far apart. The advice I got was simple: stay a reporter, don't become an investigator. I stayed a reporter. I never tried to find her.

The school wrote back. They had assessed the report and forwarded it to the appropriate institution. "Gw lumayan seneng juga." I was pretty happy, actually. I sent a short thank-you. I wanted to say I'd done it out of empathy, as a fellow high-schooler, *sesama anak SMA*, and that they'd handled it professionally. I even asked whether I should sign off "Kind Regards… Highschool student."

A month and two weeks later, an unknown number called me directly at 2 p.m., in the middle of a noisy class. A caller-ID app linked it to the university connected to the school. I didn't pick up. I decided that if they called again, I'd answer.

I don't know what that call was about. I don't know what happened with the case, or with her. That's how it should be. It was never my story.

What it cost me was a morning, some nerve, and a bit of comfort. Once you've acted on one of these, you can't pretend that scrolling past is neutral any more.

What it showed me is that "is this cringe?" is the wrong question, and a very teenage one. The real question was whether someone could act on what I knew. If yes, the embarrassment is mine to carry, and it weighs almost nothing.

I also saw how much friction sits between seeing something wrong and reporting it. A website that won't load. A form written for someone else. Business hours. None of that is a reason to stop. It does explain why most people do.

One Hour of Sleep

June – July 2026, Ungaran

The night before the Economics olympiad, I slept one hour.

That's all I have on record about the night itself. One hour. The next day was report-card day, and on the same day I sat the district round, OSN-K Economics. I'd switched over from Earth Science that year. In the OSN-K training I'd been the most active one there, and fairly strong. A grade-12 mentor who'd won a bronze in Economics knew me for it.

None of that helped at the desk. I scored under 40 out of 50. I walked out already feeling I wouldn't get through, even though statistically I still might.

On the way home I was tired and a bit down. My circle, just four of us, was busy in the group chat, noisily comparing grades. Fine. Normal. I said I didn't want to talk about grades because I was thinking about OSN. Then I ignored some of the chats.

Two of the other three were also my competition partners. One was my partner for OPSI, the research competition. The other, my deskmate for almost two years, was on my team for the AI Open Innovation Challenge, along with a girl from outside the circle who edited our demo video.

Then both partners stopped answering my messages about the competitions. Not read-and-leave. Literally no reply.

My deskmate went quiet first. He answered when the semifinal result was announced (we'd made it), stayed active for a few days, then went silent again. Meanwhile the girl on our team already had the opening of the

video ready. In a meeting with my OPSI supervisor, the teacher said my OPSI partner hadn't answered her either. So it was on purpose.

The next day I sat through a competition meeting and got scolded for not continuing OPSI.

Then came Saturday night, 21 June. I'd just bought Claude Pro, Rp390,000, and spent my savings on it because I was so excited. The OSN-P announcement came out. My name wasn't there. I was a bit shocked, and I closed it.

The full list came out the next day. About 28 students from Semarang Regency had qualified, close to last year's 30. But half or more were from private schools. Public-school places had dropped from about ten to two. Last year my school sent four, including me. This year, one.

"Disitu gw paham kalo gw itu beginner." That's when I understood I'm a beginner. I don't have much to brag about.

It felt different from the year before. "Pertama kali ambisius yang udh ready tinggal tembak doang gagal." The first time I was ambitious, ready, just had to pull the trigger, and failed. Before, my bullets and my gun weren't strong enough. This time I just aimed wrong.

I tried a comparison on for size: Musk getting pushed out at PayPal. I dropped it fast. I'd put time, energy and money into these competitions and been let down by friends who are still *bocah*, kids. The scale was nothing alike.

So what do you do with a friend group that goes silent?

I gave my AI Open partner a deadline: 12 July at most. On OPSI I'd already given up. "Udh gak ke tolong." Past saving.

I didn't want to leave the group chat dramatically. Leaving that day would have looked exactly like what it was: *ngambek*, sulking. I didn't want to give them the silent treatment either. A silent treatment invites "kamu kenapa?", what's wrong with you, and then the conversation pulls you straight back in. Instead I'd go back to a default mode. Treat them like anyone else. If anyone asked why, I'd honestly be the confused one, because the change was in me, not in them.

The plan for 13 July, the first day back, was to move seats away from the four of us. Another friend, one who'd always squeezed in as a third person on our bench, would probably take my place.

I still felt attached. Moving seats felt like betrayal. I wrote that down: it feels like betrayal, but it really is the best thing for me. Both halves of that sentence were true.

Here's what I didn't expect. The olympiad and the friends turned out to be one lesson. "Tapi bagus juga." But it's good, too. I didn't get past OSN-K, and now I know I'm not competition-oriented. A loop of competitions all the way to university isn't the game. It has to be higher-risk, and aimed at something that actually improves people's lives.

The circle taught me the same thing from the other side. I'd mixed work friends with fun friends. I called that a mistake myself. When the work went bad, so did the friendship.

One hour of sleep was a dumb way to sit an exam. But it took the whole month after it for me to see what that hour was hiding. I'd been leaning on contests and on friends to carry ambitions that were mine. Leaving the circle wasn't a way of punishing them. It was me picking up my own weight.

No Card

August – September 2026, Semarang

"Ini ada kesalahan apa, padahal udh gw crosscheck." What's the error? I already double-checked.

That was me in August, staring at a payment page. By mid-September I'd tried three ways to pay for one subscription: GoPay, an OCBC Visa, a Bank Jago Mastercard. All three failed.

I build AI apps. To build them I need cloud credits, model subscriptions, API keys. Every one of those wants a card that verifies. I'm seventeen. I don't have one that does.

Some of it was mechanical. My OCBC card was a debit card that wanted a one-time code for each transaction, and it kept getting declined. "Instant banget baru ngisi, loading bentar langsung ga bisa." Instant. I type it in, it loads for a second, rejected. I changed the card settings at 8 p.m. and tried straight away. Still no.

Some of it was me. I tried to pay Google Cloud from a Jago account holding Rp0. The AI called that a slightly cruel experiment on the laws of economics. Fair. Later I'd topped up Rp55,000 and it went through. Jago and Jenius Visa debit cards worked. BCA and OCBC didn't. I asked why, and whether I'd need a credit card.

That's where the wall is. In Indonesia you have to be 21 for a credit card. I turn 18 on 17 January 2027. That door isn't opening any time soon. I asked the obvious follow-up too: why is the minimum 21, and why do so many people over 21 end up with *pinjol*, online loan apps, instead of a proper credit card?

The errors don't explain themselves, either. One AI coding platform just said: "Verification required, please try again." That was the whole explanation.

There's another age wall. On my free Claude account I got banned three times for being a minor. Not for uploading anything. I just talked too much and they figured it out. "Literally udh gw upload KTP tapi ketahuan masih 17." I literally uploaded my ID card, and it showed I'm still 17. It didn't help.

At one point I asked whether it would be wise to borrow a close friend's debit card. I asked it like a logistics question. It didn't feel like one. It felt like asking someone to hold open a door I'm too young to open myself.

The money behind all this is small, and it isn't small. Months earlier I'd worked out that the SAT and IELTS together would cost 60 percent of my family's monthly income. My father is an *ojol*, a motorbike delivery driver for ShopeeFood. When an application asked for his designation and company, I didn't know what to type. I once asked whether it was fine to take an aptitude test on my phone, since I don't have a laptop. I own five or six dollars of Bitcoin, which I think of as learning money. I didn't have the $25 registration fee for a finance competition before its deadline, and told myself I'd find it somehow.

When I bought Claude Pro in June for Rp390,000, it took my savings. When a $20 plan came up in August, I wrote: "20 dolar itu lumayan gede sih untuk gw." Twenty dollars is a lot for me.

So I live on free tiers. I try to drain free tokens before they reset. On 25 August a free model I'd been racing to use switched to a paid one. "Anjir lah." I watched my Google Cloud credit burn through about Rp1.8 million in a week and a half, mostly on AI API calls, and did the maths on whether a $60-a-month virtual machine was worth keeping.

None of this is tragic. It's friction. But it's constant, and it changes how I build. I don't get to experiment loosely. Every call has a price. Every failed verification is an evening gone.

I've noticed that being broke made me resourceful and being underage made me careful. I know which debit cards work on which platform. I know where the free credits are. I know a budget alert is not a hard limit.

I also know where resourcefulness stops. You can't hack your way to 21. Some walls you just wait out.

So I'm waiting, and building in the meantime on whatever verifies. The card doesn't decide what I make. It only decides how slowly.

Complete Software

August – September 2026, Ungaran

"Kok gw gak lolos ya dengan lengkap nya software yang gw buat." How did I not get in, with how complete the software I built is?

That was my first message on 13 September, the day the OPSI finalists were announced. I wasn't one of them.

The OPSI project I'd called past saving in July was back on by August, and I built the software myself. It really was complete. That's the annoying part. It was a full web app: an AI micro-learning and cloud-accounting tool for micro-business owners, mostly food vendors around Banyumanik. A Node.js web app, deployed on Google Cloud Run, connected to Gemini 2.5. A dashboard, a cashbook, learning modules, an AI consultant. My mother offered it to the sub-district small-business WhatsApp group for me.

I built it in a strange window. For a lot of reasons, our research time came down to one month. Three weeks to build the product. One week to get it to participants and write the report. Day-to-day progress was watched closely.

School gave me a dispensation from morning to afternoon. I'd code all day, rest on the ride home with my phone, then code again until night. "Ajgg banget," I wrote. Insane. Coding with AI from morning to night.

And I took shortcuts. I skipped the basics you need to actually understand computer science. I looked for the fast path more than I really learned. So when Vertex AI wouldn't connect, I was stuck for two days. My first-ever Cloud Run deploy took two or three days. I was a week and a bit in, doing everything for the first time.

In early September there was a second contest, Emergent's Building Indonesia. I coded until 11 p.m. two nights in a row, debugging a full-stack app on a no-code platform where even editing an environment file meant linking an outside editor. At some point I felt I'd had enough. "Mungkin masih gw tolerir tapi ada rasa stagnan." I could still tolerate it, but there was a stagnant feeling that made me lose interest in what I was doing. Especially as a solo developer.

Solo is the word that keeps coming back. I checked my screen time: about two hours a day on Instagram and TikTok. The Elon Musk book I'd been reading got squeezed out. So did the long podcasts that used to feel like a night at the cinema. "Gw cuman curhat dengan ChatGPT." The only place I vented was ChatGPT.

A week later, OPSI said no.

Once I calmed down, the reason wasn't mysterious. OPSI judges research, not product polish. A stack like Node.js, PostgreSQL, Cloud Run and Gemini doesn't automatically make strong research. The finalists had sharper questions. Thousands of high-school reports were uploaded, and only about 65 teams made the final. A complete app is not a complete argument.

Later that month I did an honest audit. I've now had two full months of school dispensation, one for OSN in 2025 and one for OPSI in 2026. Neither had a big impact, on formal achievements or on my portfolio. Both times I thought I'd use the month for something bigger, like preparing a startup application. Both times I didn't, and not because I was lazy. Splitting focus like that turned out to be close to impossible.

The question that still bothers me: why couldn't I use those dispensations for urgent learning outside school, when normal school days are when I explore the most?

In October, Emergent placed my build in the top 200. Not in the top 100 that won anything.

I'm not spiralling about any of this. I want to be accurate about it. The product is strong enough to be a research instrument. The question attached to it needed to be much sharper. The long nights were real, but they weren't the same thing as depth. I can ship an app I only half understand. That's a skill. It's also a debt.

The hollow feeling at 11 p.m. wasn't just tiredness. It was what building alone sounds like when the judge is looking for something you haven't built.

Here's where I am now. Complete is not the same as right. I was proud of how much I'd made, and the honest answer to my own first message is that I built the wrong thing well. Next time I want the question first, the fundamentals second, and the code last. And I want at least one person in the room who isn't a model.

Short Pieces

The Flip

December 2025, Banyumanik

In kindergarten I was quiet, a crybaby but warm, with no close friend. One day I was squatting on a horizontal bar in the playground and my body flipped upside down. Everyone laughed, including me. For years I believed a sweet, slightly slow classmate had pushed me.

At sixteen the memory came back and wouldn't leave. I spent days re-running it. I moved on for a week, and then it returned. The answer came when I wasn't looking for it, walking around the house without my phone. I think I spun myself, copying the other kids, because lots of us played like that. And I think I was sitting there because that classmate was there. I wanted to show off. Instead of being helped, I got laughed at a bit.

Nobody pushed me. I'd been reading a kindergarten scene through everything that came after it. The same kindergarten had the teacher who made me cry by getting angry. She was also the only teacher who ever gave me a birthday present, once took me home, and knew my family's background.

Four Quail Eggs

January 2026, Ungaran

Before my school's first days of MBG, the free school-meal programme, I made a plan. A low-budget hygiene routine: anything that looked doubtful would go into my lunchbox, not my mouth. It felt a bit ridiculous.

Then the meal came. Bread and four quail eggs. All four were rotten. They were too white, the shells looked like they had white mould on them, and they smelled strange. A friend tried one that looked a bit fresher. He couldn't take it and threw up.

I don't have a big conclusion. Free meals for students are a good idea. Somewhere along the chain, somebody didn't check the eggs. What stays with me is how fast my ridiculous plan stopped looking ridiculous. Sometimes being paranoid is just being early.

Nobody Posted

January 2026, three days before my birthday

I never post birthday statuses for other people. Not because I dislike them. I just don't see the need. I've barely posted any status at all since COVID.

So I probably shouldn't have been surprised. I still wrote the question down. Why did nobody post a happy-birthday status for me? In my whole class only two people didn't get one: me, and a kid who's a loner, disliked, and considered naughty.

The explanation I got was reciprocity. You post for people, and they post for you. It's a ritual, not a verdict. That's obviously right. It still didn't feel great to be on that short list, next to the one kid everyone had decided to dislike.

Silence is a choice. Even a small one has a price, and this one gets billed once a year.

Co-founder

January 2026, Ungaran

A friend from another class threw his 17th birthday party at a restaurant: a clown as MC, twenty to thirty popular guests, boys seated facing girls. His olympiad friends and his classmates weren't invited. I wasn't either.

Around the same time, the friend I usually walked to the *halte*, the bus stop, left without me. I asked this friend for a ride, about a kilometre and a half. He said no. He was going home with my classmate, his girlfriend.

The next day, in front of my class, he said: "wah gw mohon mau jadi co founder, gw bosen di IG sekolah terus." Wow, I beg you, let me be your co-founder, I'm bored running the school Instagram. I literally burst out laughing. I said yes. Then I added that I'm "masih explore juga", still exploring too. His parting words: "wa gw jangan ga di bales." Don't leave my WhatsApp unanswered. I took that as a small lie. He'd never messaged me, and back in grade 10, when we made a competition video together, he was the one who left my messages unanswered.

I'd still ask him to film a pitch video. He's good at that. Co-founder is a different job.

Abroad

July 2026, Semarang

My parents aren't really supportive of studying abroad. I understand why. Nobody in my entire family line has ever studied abroad. Money is a barrier, but mostly it's mindset.

When I needed books and a prep course for the national academic test, my family moved fast, and I was grateful. But they won't move fast on what I need for applications abroad, even something as small as when to book the SAT or the online IELTS.

I'm not fully free of the same thinking. When I looked at a unconventional university in Berlin, the hardest part was my own ego. It isn't in the usual rankings, so it's not something to show off.

My older sister graduated in law from Undip. I pitched her my idea for selling AI to government. She followed the surface. Once it got to procurement and the business model, she said she didn't know. That's fair. Nobody in my family has had to know.

Rp19.3 Million

September 2026, Semarang

I got into Universitas Ciputra with a Diamond-grade scholarship. Then I read the payment letter.

Before any cuts, the total was Rp59.8 million. The scholarship and an early-payment discount took the building fee to zero and halved the tuition. What was still due came to Rp19.3 million: tuition, credit fees, and orientation.

I asked the obvious questions. "Ini lebih jelasnya apa aja yang gw bayar?" What exactly am I paying for? "Itu 19.3 spp nya spp hanya bulan ini kah? Atau semester ini?" Is that tuition just for this month, or this semester? Even the letter didn't make clear whether some of those fees were per semester or per year. The early-payment discount shrinks every month, from Rp15 million in January 2027 to Rp2.5 million by June.

My father delivers food for ShopeeFood. I don't have an ending for this one yet. Just the number, and the fact that the scholarship is real and the bill is still there.

Fuel

January 2026, Semarang

When I talked about my college and research plans with my parents, my relatives, and my older sister, the reactions came in two flavours. Confused, or sure it was unrealistic. Some version of *gaush macem macem*: don't try anything fancy. One relative found it confusing that I was asking about their economics thesis while still in high school.

In a frustrated moment, I wrote some harsh things about my family. I won't repeat them here. They came from a bad evening, not a fair assessment.

What I'll keep is this. The doubt only made my willpower stronger: "makin tambah will power nya." And one idea I still like came from my sister's shelf. I saw her Universitas Terbuka textbooks, Introductory Economics at three credits and Accounting 1 at four, and thought: I could build my own degree like this.

The people who doubt you can still leave the books lying around.